

CAVED IN Rescue work on at the under construction Silkyara-Barkot tunnel, Nov. 12; (left) the Char Dham highway near Rudraprayag, Aug. 25

AFP

THE HEAVY RAINS LED TO A THOUSAND BIG AND SMALL LANDSLIDES IN UTTARAKHAND. SOME 270 ROADS AND HIGHWAYS WERE BLOCKED FOR DAYS

tious Char Dham highway development project, is being built to protect road users from such landslides. 'Once built, this tunnel will...provide all-weather connectivity and reduce 25.6 km snow-affected length...to 4.5 km, resulting in reduction of travel time to five minutes instead of the 50 taken at present,' a statement from the Union ministry of road transport and highways (MoRTH) said a day after the accident, even as rescue operations were on.

For the past few years now, this has been the scenario on the Char Dham 'all-weather' highways. The Rs 12,000 crore project in Uttarakhand to widen 825 km of highways connecting the Gangotri, Yamunotri, Kedarnath and Badrinath shrines has consistently been in the eye of a storm this year. The monsoon rains saw around a thousand big and small landslides in the state and some 270 roads, including highways, closed for days on end. Long queues of vehicles on both sides of the breaches were a common sight. The highways leading to the Char Dham shrines were all breached many times, leaving thousands of pilgrims stranded.

It's the same story year after year. A decade after a cloudburst killed around 6,000 people in one of the worst disasters in the history of the hill state, life here is once again hostage to landslides and floods. "Goods couldn't reach the villages for days. In some places, people were paying Rs 10,000 for a cooking gas cylinder," says Hemant Dhyani, convenor of the Ganga Ahwan Movement, a citizens' collective working on the conservation of the Ganges and the Himalayas in Uttarakhand and a member of the Supreme Court-appointed high-powered committee on the Char Dham highway development project.

For the government, the cost of the natural disasters in the hill states is mounting. In neighbouring Himachal Pradesh, too, the rain wreaked havoc—the damage in roads infrastructure alone was Rs 3,000 crore, says the state government, with overall losses pegged at over Rs 8,000 crore. In Uttarakhand, Kesher Panwar, an Uttarkashi resident, says, "*Kachchi mitti ke pahaad hain yeh* (These mountains are made of loose soil). They are using huge machines to cut the hills to widen the roads, which weakens the base. One spell of heavy rain and the mud gives away," he says. Panwar lost his home in the 2013 flash floods and was one of the petitioners at the National Green Tribunal to stop the Char Dham project. The matter eventually reached the Supreme Court which, in 2021, gave a conditional clearance with several riders.

"It's not like the mountain roads were immune to natural calamities earlier. But now both the frequency and intensity have increased. And it is to do with how these roads are being built," says ecologist Anil Prakash Joshi, founder of the